Community waiting list within 18 weeks

Forecast for September 2026 · data through August 2026

The latest Community waiting list within 18 weeks result was 75.8%. For the next release, it is expected to worsen to 74.9%. The model components are mixed, but together imply a small deterioration. The current projection is off course for 78% by March 2027. Across providers, sustained favourable signals outnumber adverse ones (12 to 10).

LATEST · AUGUST 2026	FORECAST · SEPTEMBER 2026	ACTUAL
75.8%	**74.9%**	—
0.5pp above forecast	80% expected range 73.8%–75.9%	Not yet released
		Off course · 78% by March 2027

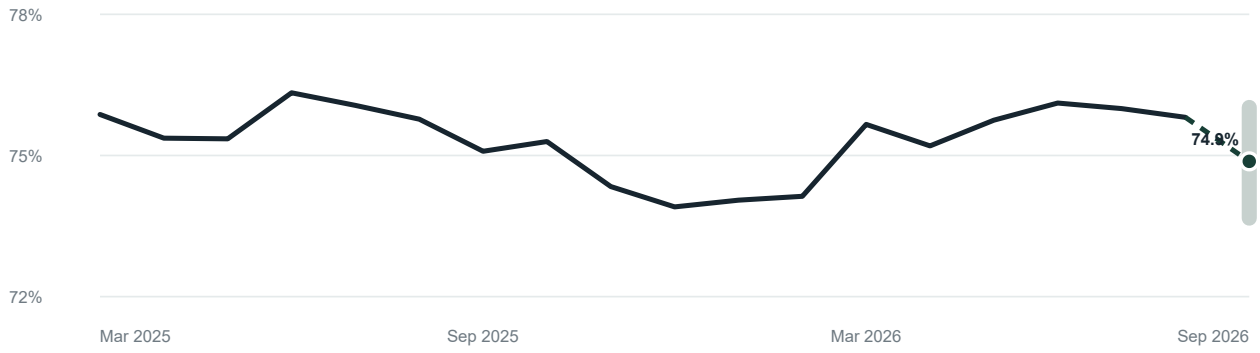
WHAT CHANGED?

Community waiting list within 18 weeks was broadly unchanged in the latest month. Total community waiting list changed by +15,513, while People within 18 weeks changed by +9,707. The percentage therefore reflects both the size of the cohort and how many were within the standard.

Monthly	Annual	Total community waiting list
-0.2pp	+0.0pp	+15,513

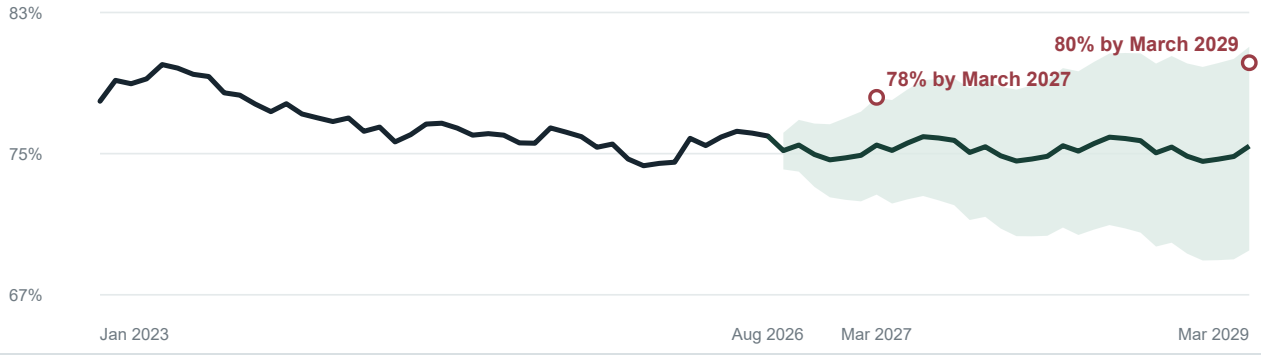
Recent performance and next release

The vertical band is the 80% expected range.



Longer-term outlook and milestones

Descriptive projection; not forced to meet targets.



Benchmark: 80% by March 2029. 2.8pp below milestone

Data: NHS England community health services waiting lists. **Targets:** Medium Term Planning Framework interim target · Medium Term Planning Framework final target

Method: Backtest-weighted ensemble of current-level seasonal movement, damped annual drift and a damped recent seasonal trend; at least 2 components are required. The final fit uses 44 consecutive months. Accuracy is tested on 12 rolling one-month-ahead forecasts. The 80% range uses empirical historical error quantiles from 12 forecast errors. Weights use inverse rolling RMSE and are shrunk toward equal weights. The pre-release commentary compares the current-level seasonal component with the combined forecast. Provider distribution and trajectory watch are shown on page 2.

Community waiting list within 18 weeks

Distribution and trajectory watch · August 2026

Provider distribution

Latest reported performance across providers. This is a comparison of current levels, not a measure of whether each provider is improving or deteriorating.



Moderate = 1–<2×; marked = at least 2× the metric-specific materiality threshold.

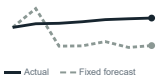
Trajectory watch

Six actual months are compared with one forecast path fixed before that window. Both lines begin at the same observed value. A low performer can be improving, while a high performer can be deteriorating. Status: Actual performance is compared with the monthly path forecast six months earlier. The displayed figure is the latest actual minus the fixed forecast for that same month; the six-month window checks persistence.

48	12	10	26
providers assessed	sustained favourable	sustained adverse	without an active signal

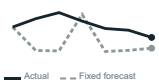
Largest sustained favourable moves

UNIVERSITY HOSPITALS PLYMOUTH NHS TRUST
Latest 80.0% · 6 months compared with a path fixed six months earlier
Forecast fixed before the six-month window



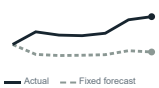
25.2pp
LATEST MONTH: ABOVE FORECAST

DONCASTER AND BASSETLAW TEACHING HOSPITALS NHS FOUNDATION TRUST
Latest 36.6% · 6 months compared with a path fixed six months earlier
Forecast fixed before the six-month window



24.4pp
LATEST MONTH: ABOVE FORECAST

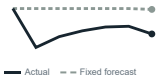
DERBYSHIRE HEALTHCARE NHS FOUNDATION TRUST
Latest 35.1% · 6 months compared with a path fixed six months earlier
Forecast fixed before the six-month window



19.9pp
LATEST MONTH: ABOVE FORECAST

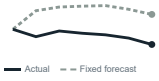
Largest sustained adverse moves

FRIMLEY HEALTH NHS FOUNDATION TRUST
Latest 79.9% · 6 months compared with a path fixed six months earlier
Forecast fixed before the six-month window



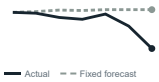
19.5pp
LATEST MONTH: BELOW FORECAST

WHITTINGTON HEALTH NHS TRUST
Latest 62.1% · 6 months compared with a path fixed six months earlier
Forecast fixed before the six-month window



16.0pp
LATEST MONTH: BELOW FORECAST

SHERWOOD FOREST HOSPITALS NHS FOUNDATION TRUST
Latest 89.8% · 6 months compared with a path fixed six months earlier
Forecast fixed before the six-month window



10.2pp
LATEST MONTH: BELOW FORECAST

Trajectory-watch rule. Six actual months are compared with the corresponding path fixed before the six-month window. The displayed gap is the latest actual minus the fixed forecast for that same month. A signal requires a material latest-month gap and at least five of six months in that direction. These are screening prompts—not league tables, causal estimates or judgements of provider quality.

Community waits by service

England · August 2026

SERVICE MIX

Where waits over 18 weeks are concentrated

Services differ greatly in size. This ranks the published service categories by the number waiting over 18 weeks; it is a descriptive breakdown, not a forecast or provider comparison.

47

services with a reported total waiting list

43

services with complete published over-18-week bands

SERVICE	TOTAL WAITING	OVER 18 WEEKS	WITHIN 18 WEEKS
Community paediatric service	174,537	129,158	26.0%
Musculoskeletal service	456,532	78,025	82.9%
Therapy interventions: Speech and language	58,114	20,122	65.4%
Podiatry and podiatric surgery	113,132	15,689	86.1%
Therapy interventions: Occupational therapy	19,992	6,015	69.9%
Nursing and Therapy support for LTCs: Continence/ colostomy	44,259	5,996	86.5%
Therapy interventions: Physiotherapy	49,316	5,406	89.0%
Therapy interventions: Dietetics	35,793	5,178	85.5%
Audiology	16,214	5,064	68.8%
Therapy interventions: Speech and language	28,297	4,710	83.4%
Rehabilitation services (integrated)	46,590	3,720	92.0%
Audiology	16,079	3,379	79.0%
Therapy interventions: Physiotherapy	20,054	2,688	86.6%
Neurorehabilitation (multi-disciplinary)	13,806	2,517	81.8%
Therapy interventions: Dietetics	8,354	2,091	75.0%

Coverage and interpretation. Ranked by the published number waiting over 18 weeks. Complete over-18 bands were available for 43 of 47 services with a reported total. Rows with suppressed or incomplete bands are excluded from the ranking. The national headline on page 1 remains the authoritative aggregate. The within-18-week percentage is total waiting less all published over-18-week bands, divided by total. NHS England notes that the sum of weekly bands may not match the total where some providers were still collecting waits by weeks; reconciliation differences are retained in the QA outputs.